



FINDING COMMUNITY HEALTH INTERNSHIPS

**A Step-by-Step Guide to Finding Paid and Unpaid
Internships**

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You want to work in community health but have no experience? That's totally fine. Community health organizations value passion, reliability, and cultural humility over a perfect resume. This guide will walk you through exactly how to find paid and unpaid internships—even if you've never worked in healthcare before.

STEP 1: DEFINE WHAT "COMMUNITY HEALTH" MEANS TO YOU

Community health is broad. It includes:

- Federally Qualified Health Centers (FQHCs) that serve low-income populations
- Nonprofits (e.g., Planned Parenthood, American Red Cross, local food banks)
- Public health departments (city, county, state)
- Community outreach programs (mobile health vans, health education)
- Advocacy organizations (e.g., NAACP health initiatives, local immigrant health coalitions)

Before you apply, ask yourself:

- What population do I care about? (e.g., unhoused, immigrants, rural communities, LGBTQ+)
- What role interests me? (e.g., health education, patient navigation, community organizing, research)

- What skills do I already have? (bilingual? good with data? strong public speaking?)

STEP 2: WHERE TO LOOK FOR INTERNSHIPS

Platform/Source	Best For	Tips
Idealist.org	Nonprofit internships worldwide	Filter by "health" and "internship"
Indeed / Glassdoor	General internships	Search "community health intern" or "public health intern"
Handshake	University-affiliated students	Set up a profile—many employers specifically recruit from Handshake
AmeriCorps VISTA	Paid service fellowships (often in community health)	1-year commitment but great benefits
Your Local Health Department	Local internships	Go to their website's "Careers" or "Volunteer" page
FQHCs	Hands-on patient care experience	Type "FQHC near me" and call the HR department
Public Health Institutes	State/regional opportunities	Example: "California Department of Public Health internships"
Your University's Career Center	Exclusive opportunities	They often have partnerships you won't find elsewhere

STEP 3: HOW TO GET AN INTERNSHIP WITH ZERO EXPERIENCE

Strategy 1: Start as a Volunteer

Many organizations hire internally for internships. Volunteer for 2-3 months (e.g., as a receptionist, data entry, or outreach assistant). Once they know you're reliable, ask about formal internships.

Strategy 2: Leverage Transferable Skills

You don't have healthcare experience? That's fine.

Did you work retail? You have customer service and conflict resolution skills. Did you babysit? You have patience and responsibility. Are you bilingual? That's a huge asset—mention it immediately.

Write a resume that highlights soft skills and adaptability.

Strategy 3: Cold Email

Find the Program Coordinator or Volunteer Manager on the organization's website.

Send a short, respectful email:

"Dear [Name], My name is [Your Name], and I'm a [Freshman/Sophomore] at [University]. I'm deeply interested in community health, particularly [specific population/issue]. I've been following your organization's work in [specific area], and I admire [specific project]. I'm reaching out to ask if you have any internship or volunteer opportunities for students with limited prior experience. I'm a hard worker, bilingual, and eager to learn. I've attached my resume. Thank you for your time!"

Strategy 4: Faculty Connections

Ask your public health, sociology, or pre-med professors if they know any community health organizations looking for students. Many professors have professional networks and can make introductions.

STEP 4: ACING YOUR INTERVIEW

Common Questions and How to Answer:

"Why are you interested in community health?"

Connect it to a personal story (e.g., "I grew up without access to a nearby clinic, so I want to help others who face similar barriers").

"What skills do you bring?"

Focus on soft skills: communication, empathy, organization, tech skills, language abilities, problem-solving.

"Why do you want this specific role?"

Do your research! Mention one specific program or project they run that excites you.

Pro Tip: Prepare 1-2 thoughtful questions for them (e.g., "What does a typical day look like?" or "How does your organization measure impact?").

STEP 5: MAKE THE MOST OF YOUR INTERNSHIP

- Show up early and stay late when possible.
- Ask for feedback regularly.
- Build relationships with staff and patients/clients.
- Keep a journal of your experiences—you'll use these stories for medical school applications.
- Connect with your supervisor to see if there are opportunities for more responsibility (e.g., leading a project, training new volunteers).

ABOUT THIS RESOURCE

This guide is part of the HealthBridge Library — free resources for every stage of your pre-health journey.

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Updated: July 2026

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